REPUBLIC OF THE PHILIPPINES • DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION

Phil-IRI Diagnostic Assessment Selection

Philippine Informal Reading Inventory • Junior High School English • Level 7-8

Reading Level: Junior High School (Diagnostic)	**Word Count:** 385 Words
Focus Skills: Literal Comprehension, Vocabulary in Context, Inferential Reasoning	**Standard Time:** 3 - 5 Minutes

The Philippine Eagle: Lord of the Skies

The Philippine Eagle (*Pithecophaga jefferyi*), acclaimed as the national bird of the Philippines, is one of the rarest, largest, and most majestic birds of prey anywhere in the world. Endemic strictly to the archipelago, it survives across only four major islands: Luzon, Samar, Leyte, and Mindanao. Characterized by its magnificent crown of dagger-like brown and cream plumage, striking grey-blue eyes, and a formidable curved bill, the Philippine Eagle stands as an unrivaled symbol of biological heritage and rainforest vitality.

In its native habitat, the eagle reigns as an apex predator at the absolute summit of the tropical food chain. Reaching a wingspan of over seven feet, it navigates dense, towering forest canopies with astonishing agility to hunt Philippine deer, flying lemurs, palm civets, and monkeys. Biologists consider the presence of an eagle pair a prime ecological indicator: a single breeding pair requires between twenty-five to fifty square miles of undisturbed virgin forest to hunt and nurture a single chick. Consequently, healthy eagle territories signify thriving, balanced ecosystems capable of sustaining thousands of indigenous plant and wildlife species.

Tragically, this magnificent raptor now faces grave peril. Decades of rampant commercial logging, agricultural expansion, and habitat fragmentation have decimated more than eighty percent of the Philippine primary rainforest cover. Today, scientists estimate that fewer than four hundred breeding pairs remain in the wild, placing the species under the critically endangered classification on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List.

Saving the Philippine Eagle demands united community action and scientific stewardship. Conservation organizations, local indigenous forest rangers, and youth education initiatives are combining forces to protect remaining sanctuaries in Mount Apo and the Sierra Madre mountain range. Safeguarding our national bird is more than a struggle to preserve a single species; it is a sacred pledge to defend the life-giving rainforests that secure clean water, fresh air, and ecological protection for future Filipino generations.

Assessment Directions: *After reading the passage carefully, tap* ***'Take Quiz'*** *below to evaluate your reading speed, vocabulary comprehension, and critical deduction.*